

Battle of Ia Drang Valley

In November 1965, American and North Vietnamese troops fought their first large-scale battle, in the Ia Drang Valley of South Vietnam's Central Highlands. Five days of brutal fighting established a pattern for Vietnam War battles that would repeat again and again.

◀◀ BEFORE

Dramatically higher troop levels in the fall of 1965 provided US commanders with enough resources to take on the NVA.

TAKING UP POSITION

North Vietnamese Army (NVA) forces had already infiltrated South Vietnam via the [Ho Chi Minh Trail](#).

GEARING UP

President Johnson's [escalation of the war](#) increased the number of US ground troops, providing enough manpower for major battles as well as counterinsurgency patrols.

The Battle of Ia Drang Valley was part of the second phase of a month-long operation known as the Pleiku Campaign. The first phase provided relief for the US Special Forces camp at Plei Me, which was besieged by the North Vietnamese Army (NVA) for a week in October 1965.

In the second phase, elements of the American First Air Cavalry Division were deployed to draw the NVA away from Plei Me.

Battle begins

The operation, which was known as Silver Bayonet I, was an early demonstration of the air mobility concept, in which ground troops were dropped onto and withdrawn from the battlefield by helicopter. After a brief artillery bombardment to clear the initial landing zone (LZ X-Ray), helicopters began landing eight at a time, and the men of the First Air Cavalry took up defensive positions.

The battalion was dropped into the Ia Drang Valley on November 14, to engage with North Vietnamese units operating in the area. They were quickly confronted by a large force at a well-defended base camp. The battalion came under fire almost immediately, and within two hours the battle was on: multiple American companies came under heavy attack, and one platoon was cut off from the rest of the battalion entirely.